WIDOW MARSH

Introduced: Day 5 one-time job — help her move furniture **Location:** Her house, south end of main road. White paint gone gray. Garden that used to be tended. **Role:** Previous incident witness, lore source, emotional mirror for Marcus **Unlock Condition:** Marcus finds and returns her son's personal item

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WHO SHE IS

Eleanor Marsh is somewhere in her late sixties though she looks older — the kind of age that comes from carrying something heavy for too long. She was sharp once. People who knew her twenty years ago will tell you that if you ask, and the telling of it has a sadness underneath it like describing a house before the fire.

Her son was **Jacob Marsh.** Twenty-two years old. He came back from a night on the north road **five years ago** changed — torn clothes, no wounds, no memory. Exactly like Marcus. Eleanor recognized something wrong in him immediately the way mothers do. She watched it progress over the following weeks. She covered for him when people asked questions. She told Pruitt he'd gone to stay with relatives when Jacob stopped being able to stay in the house at night. She told herself she was protecting him.

On the night of the second full moon after his infection Jacob transformed completely and ran into the north woods. He did not come back as Jacob.

Eleanor told no one what she saw. She helped Calhoun construct the story — drowning accident, body never recovered, tragic — because Calhoun came to her the morning after and told her what her options were. She has been living inside that choice for **five years.**

Her mind hasn't broken. It has *bent* — hard and permanent — around the shape of what she did. She functions. She makes tea. She tends what's left of her garden. When conversation gets within reach of Jacob or the woods or that year, something behind her eyes goes somewhere else and she talks about the weather until you leave.

FIRST MEETING — Day 5 Job

The job is simple. She needs furniture moved — a heavy wardrobe from the upstairs bedroom to the downstairs sitting room. She couldn't do it alone and couldn't ask anyone she knew.

She opens the door and looks at Marcus for a long moment before stepping aside to let him in.

The house is clean but sparse. Things that were probably here for decades — a chair, a side table, curtains — sit with the particular stillness of objects that haven't been touched in a long time. On the mantle: a photograph. A young man, maybe twenty, grinning at whoever is holding the camera. Something leans against the wall nearby — a baseball bat, old, well-used, a name burned into the handle.

Jacob.

Eleanor is already leading Marcus upstairs before he can look too long.

She does not make conversation during the job. She directs. She thanks him when it's done. She pays him exactly what was agreed.

At the door she pauses.

"You're the one been staying at Hattie's," she says. Not quite a question.

"Yes ma'am."

She looks at him — not through him, not around him. Directly. Something in her face moves the way faces move when they're deciding something.

Then it closes.

"You be careful on that north road," she says. And goes inside.

MARSH_MET set JACOB_PHOTOGRAPH_SEEN set — Marcus noticed. Filed away.

THE ITEM — Finding Jacob's Compass

> *Discovered during north road investigation, Visit 2+ Requires* ATTACK_SITE_FOUND *and* MARKERS_DESTROYED

On the second or later visit to the north road, Marcus's enhanced senses pull him off the main trail. Twenty feet into the tree line, half-buried in leaf rot and two years of weather — a brass compass. Tarnished but intact. Engraved on the back:

J.M. — Find your way home. — Mama

Marcus holds it.

The woods are quiet around him. Whatever made the drag trail, whatever left the claw marks on the trees — this compass was here before any of that. Or during it. Someone had it and then didn't anymore.

JACOB_COMPASS_FOUND set **Inventory item added:** *Jacob's Compass*

> *Marcus can use the compass as a navigation tool in the north woods — it points north accurately but occasionally, at night, the needle drifts toward something that isn't north. Toward the deep woods. Toward the pack's territory. It doesn't do this every time. Just sometimes.*

RETURNING THE COMPASS — The Unlock

Marcus brings it to Eleanor's door. She answers and sees what he's holding before she sees his face. She goes very still.

The color leaves her in a specific way — not faint, not falling. Just the particular stillness of someone whose body has been braced against something for two years and just felt it arrive.

"Where," she says. One word. Barely sound.

"North road. In the tree line off the main trail."

She takes it from him. Both hands. She holds it the way you hold something you thought you'd never see again and had taught yourself not to want back. Her thumbs find the engraving without looking.

She steps back from the door.

"Come in," she says.

THE CONVERSATION — What She Gives

Eleanor makes tea. Marcus doesn't ask why. They sit at the kitchen table and she holds the compass and looks at it and begins to talk in the way of someone who has been not-talking for so long that once it starts there's no architecture left to stop it.

She doesn't look at Marcus while she talks. She talks to the compass.

WHAT SHE TELLS HIM — Sequential

First — Jacob: *"He was a good boy. Everyone says that about their children but Jacob — he was genuinely good. Patient. Funny."* She runs her thumb across the engraving. *"He went out that road at night. I told him not to. He said he'd be careful."*

She is quiet for a moment.

"He came back in the morning. Clothes like yours." She glances at Marcus then. Brief. *"I knew. Soon as I saw him standing in the yard I knew something was different in him. A mother knows."*

Second — The Progression: *"It was slow at first. Just — restlessness. He couldn't sleep. He'd be up walking the house at three in the morning. His appetite changed. He'd eat and eat and still look hungry."* Her voice is steady. The steadiness of someone who has rehearsed this in private a thousand times. *"Then the moon started mattering. I could see it — the fuller it got the harder it was for him to be still."*

"Did he— "

"He never hurt anyone," she says sharply. Then quieter: *"Not that I know of."*

Third — The Cover-Up: Here her voice changes. The rehearsed steadiness cracks in one specific place and she presses through it.

"Aldous Calhoun came to me. Morning after the second full moon. Jacob had gone into the woods and I didn't know yet he wasn't coming back." She sets the compass down. *"Aldous knew. He'd seen it before — or his daddy had, he said. He told me what people would say. What they'd do. He told me the story to tell and I—"*

She stops.

"I told it," she says. *"I told them Jacob drowned. I buried an empty box in the churchyard."* Her hands are flat on the table now. *"I thought I was protecting his memory. I think now I was protecting myself."*

Silence.

Fourth — What She Knows About The Pack: *"Jacob didn't drown. You know that. Whatever he became — he's still out there."* She looks at Marcus fully for the first time since he sat down. *"Isn't he."*

[PLAYER CHOICE]

A — "I don't know. But I think so." She nods slowly. Something in her settles — not relief, but the particular stillness of a confirmed truth being easier than an unconfirmed one. *"The woods keep them,"* she says. *"Whatever they become — the woods keep them. Calhoun knows that. That's why he never pushed for a real search."* MARSH_JACOB_IN_PACK — confirmed. CALHOUN_KNEW_JACOB set.

B — Confirm it — "There's a pack in those woods. Jacob is likely part of it." She closes her eyes. When she opens them they are very clear. *"Can he come back?"* The question sits between them.
[PLAYER CHOICE — answer her]

- *"I don't know yet."* → HUMANITY +5. Honest. She nods.
- *"I'm going to find out."* → HUMANITY +10. She looks at him for a long moment. Then she reaches across the table and puts her hand over his briefly.
- *"I don't think so."* → HUMANITY -5. The truth costs something to say. She sits with it. *"No,"* she says quietly. *"I don't think so either."*

C — Deflect — "I'm still trying to understand what happened to me." She studies him. *"That's what he said too. In the beginning."* She picks up the compass again. *"Don't wait too long to stop understanding and start deciding."*

FIFTH — CALHOUN'S HISTORY

> *Only unlocked if CALHOUN_PREPARING already set when this conversation happens.*

If Marcus mentions the chain purchase — the rope, the equipment — Eleanor's expression does something complicated.

"He's done it before," she says quietly. *"His daddy did it first. When the last one came — before Jacob — they contained it. Chained it in the root cellar of the old Pruitt barn. Kept it through three full moons until it — until the person died."*

She looks at her hands.

"That's Aldous's solution. Chain it. Wait. Let the host die. Call it a disappearance."

A beat.

"He was going to do that to Jacob. I found out. That's why I agreed to the story — to keep him from doing that instead."

CALHOUN_METHOD_KNOWN set — Calhoun's containment plan is now fully understood. He doesn't want to cure the infection. He wants to outlast it. And the host dies in the process.

SUBSEQUENT VISITS

Eleanor doesn't send Marcus away after the first conversation. She doesn't invite him back either. But the door opens when he knocks.

Visit	What She Offers	Condition
2	Jacob's description — what he looked like as the infection progressed. Useful for recognizing Curtis's trajectory.	JACOB_COMPASS_RETURNED
3	The name of the previous victim before Jacob — two generations back. A traveling preacher. Calhoun's father handled that one.	CADE_SAW_SOMETHING cross-reference — Cade saw Jacob, not the preacher
4	Where Jacob went the night he didn't come back — a specific path into the north woods. Shortcut to Takoda's shack if SHACK_FOUND not yet set	MARSH_TRUSTS_MARCUS
5	The root cellar — the old Pruitt barn where Calhoun's father chained the previous victim. Still there. Still usable. Marcus can find it.	CALHOUN_METHOD_KNOWN

ELEANOR & THE OTHER CHARACTERS

Hattie: They were close once. After Jacob they stopped being close without ever having an argument about it. Hattie knew Eleanor was lying about the drowning. Eleanor knew Hattie knew. They have been maintaining a careful, sad distance ever since. If HATTIE_DEAD — Eleanor finds out and sits in her kitchen alone and doesn't come to the door for two days.

Cade: She attends his church every Sunday and sits in the same pew and stares at the empty box in the churchyard with Jacob's name on it. Cade has given the eulogy he gave at Jacob's funeral over in his head many times since his faith broke. He thinks about Eleanor when he drinks.

Pruitt: He took the drowning story because it was clean and Eleanor was credible and Calhoun vouched for it. Some part of him knew. The part that has been looking at the north woods on that map in his office for two years.

Calhoun: She is terrified of him and hates herself for it. He has never threatened her directly since the morning after Jacob disappeared. He has never needed to.

SCENE NOTES

- **The compass drifting toward the pack at night** is a quiet mechanic that rewards players who pay attention. It's pointing toward Jacob. If Marcus ever reaches the pack's inner territory the compass is pointing directly at the alpha's location. Jacob Marsh has been in those woods for two years.
- **Jacob and Curtis are parallel cases** — young men selected by the alpha, both with mothers or people who loved them, both now part of the pack. Eleanor is what Marcus's future looks like if he doesn't find Curtis in time. That parallel should land without the game stating it.
- **Calhoun's method — chain the host and wait** reframes every interaction Marcus has had with Calhoun. The hostility wasn't just racism operating normally. He has been assessing Marcus since Day 1, deciding when and how to act. The chains are already somewhere. The cellar is already prepared.
- **"Don't wait too long to stop understanding and start deciding"** is the best thing anyone says to Marcus in the whole game. Eleanor learned that lesson too late for Jacob.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
MARSH_MET	Day 5 furniture job
JACOB_PHOTOGRAPH_SEEN	First visit observation
JACOB_COMPASS_FOUND	North road investigation
JACOB_COMPASS_RETURNED	Returned to Eleanor
MARSH_JACOB_IN_PACK	Conversation choice A or B
CALHOUN_KNEW_JACOB	Conversation — Eleanor reveals it
CALHOUN_METHOD_KNOWN	Cross-reference with CALHOUN_PREPARING
MARSH_TRUSTS_MARCUS	Three visits completed honestly
JACOB_PATH_KNOWN	Visit 4 — shortcut to north woods
ROOT_CELLAR_KNOWN	Visit 5 — Calhoun's containment location
PREVIOUS_VICTIM_PREACHER	Visit 3 — cross-references Cade's account

LEADS TO

Discovery	Thread Advanced
CALHOUN_METHOD_KNOWN	Calhoun confrontation thread — Marcus now knows what Calhoun is building toward
JACOB_PATH_KNOWN	North woods shortcut — accelerates pack investigation
ROOT_CELLAR_KNOWN	Late game option — root cellar becomes a possible location for the final confrontation
PREVIOUS_VICTIM_PREACHER	Cross-references with Cade — two witnesses now confirm the cycle is generational
Compass night drift	Navigation tool for finding the alpha's location in endgame